

TIE-BREAK T.M. Nair Bridge Road in T. Nagar, one of the pathways to be renamed in Chennai

O HAVE NO CASTE

ed names to be wiped off all public places, critics cry bias

drawn from Tamil poets, flowers, local icons, or historically prominent figures.

A PERIYARIST STRIKE

The deadlines shows the state is dead serious: local bodies must first submit lists, then conduct public consultations and accept petitions, issue formal notifications, and send the finalised names to the state government by mid-November. The full transition is to be accomplished by November 19. In the capital city alone, the Greater Chennai Corporation plans to rename around 3,400 streets bearing caste-linked names before the deadline, using neutral substitutions or at least initials if no suitable replacements are decided upon.

In 1929, the Self-Respect Conference at Chengalpattu, held under Periyar's leadership, passed a resolution urging people to drop caste and community titles from their names. As a symbolic reform that harks back to that gesture, the idea is sweeping in its ambition and yet not immune from controversy. AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami has accused the DMK government of using the exercise as a vehicle for partisan memory-making, particularly by favouring Stalin's father M. Karunanidhi, the former DMK CM.

Takeaways

- **All streets, localities, water bodies to get caste-neutral names by November 19**
- **Opposition calls it 'Street Karunanidhi', with AIADMK icons MGR, Jaya ignored**

'FAMILY FAVOURITISM'

Moreover, EPS alleges the government is sidelining icons like the AIADMK lodestars M.G. Ramachandran and Jayalalithaa, besides many others, while elevating Karunanidhi. He promises that, if his party returns to power, the renaming order will be revoked. BJP's K. Annamalai also critiques the exclusion of the two ex-CMs from the state's "icon" list. The list of suggested replacements presently comprises the names of 16 reformers and literary icons. The last on the list is indeed Kalaignar, the popular appellation of Karunanidhi, seen as a literary icon in his own right with a vital role in the Dravidian movement.

In response, finance minister Thangam Thennarasu has accused Palaniswami of politicising a socially progressive move. He clarifies that the names listed in the government order are merely suggestive, not prescriptive, leaving ample room for local choice.

Another flashpoint is the G.D. Naidu Elevated Expressway in Coimbatore—a 10-km corridor inaugurated this year. Critics point out it bears a surname that is in breach of the renaming logic. The government defends its decision on grounds of regional legacy and public identity. Thennarasu says Naidu was a celebrated scientist and Coimbatore native, and retaining his full name is essential for public recognition.

Observers note the real test lies in how far communities themselves can shape the renaming process instead of merely accepting it. Will new names truly unsettle local hierarchies, soften address-based stigma, and redefine belonging? Or will it all be symbolic? ■